

INDIA'S REACTION

Collateral Damage

India is worried that the internal strife in Pakistan may soon spill over on its borders. Also the gains of the peace process may be negated.

While India is concerned about developments on the western flank, it is treading cautiously to avert accusations of interference in Pakistan's internal affairs. So when General Musharraf declared Emergency in Pakistan, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee mildly remarked: "India hopes for the start of the democratic process at the earliest." India's high-maintenance relationship with Pakistan has yielded few dividends so far. Hence the muted response. For once, Pakistan cannot blame it on India. While India has lived with dictatorial and military regimes in the neighbourhood, it was hoping Musharraf would transfer power to a democratically elected leader, ushering in stability and enabling India to capitalise on the people-to-people linkages it has built with Pakistan over the past few years. While the return to democracy may be delayed, there is still hope that Musharraf will give in to sustained US pressure, paving way for a democratic government.

The bigger impact will be on the fragile composite dialogue process, whose fifth round was to be held early next year. Even the little progress on Kashmir, Siachen and Sir Creek is in danger of being shelved. India's other major concern is cross-border terrorism. If the stalemate continues, it will give jihadis ample opportunity to orchestrate violent attacks on

India. The troubled region of Swat, where militants are embroiled in clashes with the security forces, is not far from the line of control; if the conflict spirals out of control, India is bound to be affected.

There is also the big question of Pakistan's nuclear arsenal, which could land up in wrong hands. It is imperative for the international community, to work together to ensure that the weapons are secure. Last but not the least, economic cooperation between India and Pakistan is also likely to be undermined by the General's action. Already, business delegations headed to India, including one from the Federation of Pakistan Chambers of Commerce, are cancelling their visits. If the uncertainty persists, trade through the recently-opened land route from Attari might suffer. Bilateral trade is expected to be stagnant at \$1.6 billion a year (Rs 6,400 crore) for a while. As Pakistan plunges into a crisis, lasting peace between the two neighbours seems more distant a possibility than ever.

by Saurabh Shukla



NEIGHBOURLY CONCERNS: Manmohan with Musharraf during his 2005 visit to Delhi

Islamabad, "but it is highly unlikely that the decision was taken without her knowledge and acquiescence. It removed the main obstacle to Musharraf staying in power as well as the main threat to Bhutto's political future. Their alliance is natural."

Bhutto flew into Islamabad on November 6 reportedly for consultations with other political forces under the banner of the Alliance for Restoration of Democracy. But most analysts believe the real mission was further negotiations with the General. There is some speculation that she may even have accepted a postponement of general elections—due by January 15 under the pre-Emergency scenario—in return for greater political benefits and under the guise of battling extremism and "restoring normalcy."

External pressure on Musharraf may make a delay in general elections—much as the ruling PML hardliners may want it—unlikely. But the lack of street protests by political parties will give him heart. Without mass mobilisation by organised political forces, the current protests are likely to flounder in the face of the harsh government crackdown. "One must remember that Musharraf's main constituency is the army and it is unlikely to move against him unless it feels things are spiraling out of control on the streets," says political commentator Babar Ayaz.

For the time being, Musharraf has ensured that his chosen successor, the newly appointed Vice-Chief of Army Staff General Ashfaq Kiyani, is a loyalist and professional who is unlikely to support any move against his boss. If Musharraf does indeed take off his uniform by November 15—as he is being pressured to do by the West and Bhutto—Kiyani would succeed him as the powerful army chief. If he manages to strike a deal with Bhutto, he may yet survive in the near future, to the likely relief of his Western supporters. But the damage that has been done to his standing and legitimacy is immense and public resentment and disgust is likely to keep bubbling beneath the surface. And as analyst I.A. Rehman quoting an age-old adage, says "acts born of such despair carry the seeds of their own destruction."

WHILE INDIA IS NOT BEING BLAMED AS USUAL FOR THE UNREST IN PAKISTAN, THE INTERNAL CRISIS WILL RESULT IN STALLING OF TRADE INITIATIVES.